



fedora 10

An Effortless Upgrade

...but is it really worth it?

These days, it is very difficult to highlight the visible and noticeable changes in a distribution. As it is, there is a reluctance to upgrade in case some working application breaks down. In the absence of anything striking, a reasonable position can be, "Why bother?" If the cost of upgrading is low, more people may upgrade. Hence, aside from the noticeable differences, we will discuss a couple of lesser-known techniques to upgrade Fedora with less effort.

What's different?

Can a user tell that the machine is now upgraded? Of course—the boot up screen is different. There is a nice colourful progress bar as the system boots. Then, the default wallpaper is different. After that, the usage is about the same as before. My personal view is that not noticing a change is an advantage. There will be no need for retraining. That said, here are some of my observations:

1. Fedora 9 introduced KDE4 and it caused a lot of problems for KDE3 users. Once KDE4.1 came, I actually switched from being a predominantly GNOME user to a predominantly KDE user. I liked the sparse desktop. I liked the Dolphin file manager, particularly the split mode and the terminal panel within Dolphin. I got used to the new menu system. Fedora 10 continues with the enhancements in KDE4. The change most noticeable for me was in the Amarok player. It left me confused. I can play the music but at times can't figure out whether I have found a bug or haven't learnt how to use Amarok! I suppose I will get used to the new interface and the additional capabilities, or switch to Rhythmbox!
2. The other major change is in OpenOffice.org. Fedora 10 now includes version 3.0. An OpenOffice.org 2 user will be perfectly at ease with the new version. While I was writing this article, the KDE desktop started behaving oddly. Although OpenOffice.org worked perfectly fine, the KDE menus and the clock widget did not get displayed properly when using the proprietary Nvidia driver (not supported by Fedora). But the display was fine if the AIGLX option was off and the composite option was disabled. However, on GNOME, even with the desktop effects enabled, the behaviour was as expected.
3. The login page of GDM includes a form to set convenient universal access features. Being able to increase the text size with a simple click will be especially convenient for older users. As on Fedora 9, GDM still has a bug of not recognising *xdmcp* connections. A patch is available on the forums, but the patched version is not yet available from the repositories. As is common on Linux, a bug is not a major bottleneck. We can use KDM instead.
4. Switching to the new Plymouth system initialisation system did not make a noticeable impact on the booting time on my desktops (from power-on to the login page). I suspect that the speed up may be noticeable if there are lots of services that are started, and more savings may come if the kernel does not have to rediscover all the devices and reconfigure the hardware every time it boots. A gain of the new booting process is that diagnosing start up problems on Debian-based distributions and Fedora will now be similar. It all starts with `/etc/event.d/rcS`. I am reminded of a comment in a mainframe code: "This is where you start, where you end up is your problem!"